

OPS-RB-003 - Incident Escalation Procedure

Operational Procedure | Operations

Document ID	OPS-RB-003	Seller ID	Organization-wide
Department	Operations	Classification	INTERNAL
Owner	Neha Gupta	Created Date	2025-09-02
Related Scenario ID	SC-003, SC-008, SC-012	Document Type	Operational Procedure

1. Purpose

This procedure defines how an issue moves from detection to the correct owner, at the correct severity, within a defined time. It covers technical incidents, security incidents and account risk events.

Its purpose is to remove judgement from routing and timing, so that the quality of an escalation does not depend on who happens to receive the report.

2. Scope

Applies to every issue raised by a seller, detected by monitoring, or identified internally, that affects service availability, data correctness, security or account standing.

Does not cover routine seller questions with no service impact, which are handled entirely within Support.

3. Severity Definitions

Severity	Definition	Examples
SEV-1	Shared platform path degraded, or irreversible harm accruing now	Order placement failing platform-wide; perishable fulfilment blocked; confirmed credential compromise
SEV-2	Single account or single flow materially wrong, recoverable	Settlement shortfall; stale inventory causing oversells; duplicate refunds
SEV-3	Incorrect behaviour with limited or deferred impact	Reporting lag; a data quality defect not yet affecting transactions
SEV-4	Cosmetic or single-record issue	An individual listing attribute wrong

3.1 Severity Is Set By Harm, Not By Volume

A low record count can be SEV-1. 2,100 undispatched orders would be SEV-2 on most accounts; on a perishable account where a missed slot destroys the goods, it is SEV-1, because the harm is irreversible within the response window.

Conversely a high record count can be SEV-3. A nine-hour stale settlement feed affecting thousands of records was SEV-3 in June 2026 because no money had moved incorrectly and the cycle had not closed.

Ask two questions: is the harm reversible, and is it still accruing.

4. Escalation Timeframes

Severity	Acknowledge	Escalate to owning function	Notify Business
SEV-1	5 minutes	15 minutes	30 minutes
SEV-2	30 minutes	2 hours	Same working day
SEV-3	4 hours	1 working day	Next account review
SEV-4	1 working day	3 working days	Not required

Timeframes are measured from first report or first alert, whichever is earlier. An alert that fires and is acknowledged without being assessed does not stop the clock.

5. Routing

Issue character	Owning function	Secondary
Service unavailable, slow or erroring	Engineering	Operations
Data incorrect, stale, duplicated or missing	Engineering	Operations for recovery
Credential, access or security event	IT	Engineering
Account standing, risk or suspension	Operations	Business
Commercial terms, tier or policy exception	Business	Operations
Fulfilment, label or dispatch failure	Operations	Engineering

Where the character is unclear, route to Engineering and Operations jointly rather than choosing. Parallel assessment is cheaper than a misrouted escalation.

6. Procedure

Step 1 - Acknowledge and Classify

1. Acknowledge to the reporter within the severity timeframe.
2. Establish whether the issue is account-specific or platform-wide. Test against a second account before assuming it is account-specific.
3. Set severity using section 3. Record the reasoning if the severity is not obvious from record count.

Step 2 - Establish Facts Before Escalating

An escalation must carry facts, not a restatement of the complaint. At minimum:

- What is observed, with a quantity.
- When it started, or the earliest evidenced point.
- Whether it is account-specific or broader.
- What has been ruled out.
- A hypothesis, where one is available.

A support engineer who sampled twenty product records across four brands in August 2026 was able to escalate with a specific hypothesis - a size conversion applied twice - rather than a report of rising returns. That sampling removed roughly a day from diagnosis.

Do not delay a SEV-1 escalation to gather facts. Escalate immediately and continue gathering in parallel.

Step 3 - Escalate

- 1. Open an incident record and assign the owning function.
- 2. State the severity and the reasoning.
- 3. Attach the facts from Step 2.
- 4. Name the seller counterpart if seller communication is required.
- 5. For SEV-1 and SEV-2, notify Business within the timeframe in section 4.

Step 4 - Maintain Communication

Severity	Internal update cadence	Seller update cadence
SEV-1	Every 30 minutes	Hourly, or as agreed with the seller
SEV-2	Every 2 hours	At escalation, at root cause, at resolution
SEV-3	Daily	At resolution
SEV-4	At resolution	At resolution

Some sellers expect a specific cadence. Where an account has an agreed cadence, it overrides the table. Record the agreed cadence against the account.

Step 5 - Reassess Severity

Severity is not fixed at classification. Reassess when new information arrives.

Escalating severity mid-incident is normal and should not be treated as an admission of error. A return-rate data quality issue raised at SEV-3 in August 2026 was raised to SEV-1 two days later once the commercial scale and the proximity to an automated suspension threshold were understood.

Step 6 - Hand Off To Recovery

When the immediate cause is mitigated, hand off to the Service Recovery Procedure with a named Operations recovery owner. Do not close an incident at mitigation. Service health is not data correctness.

7. Security Escalation

Security events follow a separate path with a shorter clock.

- 1. Any suspected credential exposure, unauthorised access or data exposure is **SEV-1 by default**, regardless of confirmed impact.
- 2. Escalate to IT immediately. The Platform Administrator owns the incident.
- 3. The Platform Administrator may authorise immediate containment, including credential rotation, **without seller consent and without waiting for seller readiness**.
- 4. Classify the incident record RESTRICTED at creation. Do not discuss detail in CONFIDENTIAL or INTERNAL channels.
- 5. Treat an exposed credential as compromised. Absence of evidence of use is not evidence of non-use.

Containment that interrupts a seller's service is acceptable where the alternative risk is larger. Rotating a credential in April 2026 broke a seller's feeds for 80 minutes; the alternative was leaving write access to a

price feed in the hands of an unknown party.

8. Account Risk Escalation

Automated account actions, including suspension, escalate to Operations as the policy owner, with Business notified within 30 minutes.

Where an automated action may have been triggered by a platform defect, establish that before defending the action. Pull the underlying metric as a trend, not as the trailing average the rule evaluated, and check for an open platform defect linked to the account.

9. Exceptions

A severity may be set lower than section 3 implies where a compensating control bounds the harm, the reasoning is recorded, and Business is informed.

An escalation timeframe may be missed only where the delay is recorded with a reason. A missed SEV-1 timeframe is itself reportable at the post-incident review.

10. Verification and Post-Incident Actions

1. Confirm the escalation timeframes that were met and missed.
2. Confirm whether detection was internal or by a seller. Seller detection is a detection gap and must be raised as a preventive action.
3. Confirm whether an alert existed, fired, and was assessed. An alert that fired and was acknowledged on an assumption is a process failure, not a monitoring success.
4. Record the final severity and whether it changed during the incident.

11. Revision History

Version	Date	Change
1.0	2024-05-06	Initial procedure
2.0	2025-09-02	Severity defined by reversibility of harm rather than volume
2.1	2026-05-04	Requirement to test against a second account before assuming account-specific
2.2	2026-06-20	Alert acknowledgement does not stop the escalation clock
2.3	2026-09-22	Account risk escalation path added